

and potentially profitability by allowing leaders to pinpoint "gaps" currently present. Once the review is completed it will allow leaders to better focus the division/department resources and energy on those identified areas for improvement. This exercise is to identify the current and projected needs of the division/department. Here are four areas to think about while completing the Workforce Gap exercise:

- Retention Gaps - Identify retention gaps from current team members challenges and trends
- Recruitment Gaps - Identify recruitment gaps resulting from current team member challenges and trends
- Succession Planning Gaps - Identify succession planning gaps resulting from current team member challenges and trends
- Implications - Describe the implications if the gaps that currently exist are not successfully addressed by the workforce plan

### Risk Analysis

This exercise is to identify immediate and future risks based on the current team member gaps. There are three questions to the Risk exercise:

- Retention Risk- Identify retention risks resulting from current team member challenges and trends
- Recruitment Risks - Identify recruitment risks resulting from current team member challenges and trends
- Succession Planning Risks - Identify succession planning risks resulting from current team member challenges and trends

### Action Planning and KPIs

The last step in the SWOT, Supply and Demand, Workforce Gaps and Risk Analysis is where you will formulate a specific Action Plan with KPIs to address the gaps that have been identified. This will be done by identifying 1-2 year initiatives as well as 3-5 year initiatives. A sample template has been created [here](#)

The above steps are just a recommendation and a starting point for leaders. There are many great resources and templates on the web regarding how to conduct a SWOT, workforce gap analysis and create an action plan. This is meant as a guide and to start the conversations. Workforce planning has many benefits to a division/department, including team member retention, career development, top talent identification and can make budgeting and forecasting for the division/department a more data driven exercise. It also allows division/departments to respond quickly and more strategically to changes or emerging challenges in the market, workforce and overall business. Please reach out to your assigned PBP if you would like to partner on this exercise or have additional questions.

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## SECTION: leadership/1-1/\_index.md

Maintaining an effective and efficient agenda is important to get the best out of the 1-1 (read as: one to one) meetings you have with your team members. Furthermore this page will take you through other tips and tricks to conduct an effective 1-1 meeting.

## The 1-1 Agenda

1. Make sure you use a consistent agenda format for each 1-1.
1. Both parties add items to the agenda. Preferably, the majority added by the team member. If the manager puts more than half of the items on the agenda this is an indication that something is wrong.
1. Reference the suggested format for leadership as necessary.

## Conducting a 1-1

1. It's advisable to schedule 1-1's at least once a week. The choice of synchronous or asynchronous meetings can be made by the manager and their direct report, depending on their preferences and needs. To avoid prolonged periods without face-to-face communication, it is preferable for the manager and their direct report to have a minimum of two regularly scheduled synchronous 1-1s every month, barring any PTO or leave from work.
  1. For example, some managers schedule 1-1s on alternating weeks, with one week for synchronous meetings and the next week for asynchronous meetings. This approach allows for more dedicated focus time and aligns with our priority of emphasizing asynchronous communication.
1. Create a Google doc as the agenda and set the sharing settings exclusively between you and the team member. This should not be a public document because performance feedback should be as private as possible.
1. From High Output Management (edited slightly for language):
  1. "A key point about a one-on-one: it should be regarded as the reports's meeting, with its agenda and tone set by them ... issues that preoccupy and nag the individual contributor."
  1. How often you should have 1-1 meetings: "The answer is the job- or task-relevant maturity of each of your individual contributors. In other words, how much experience does a given report have with the specific task at hand?...the most effective management style instance varies from very close to very loose supervision as a report's task maturity increases."
1. Bill Campbell, executive coach to top executives at Google, had a suggested approach to the 1-1. Instead of leaving the conversation open, he required both the manager and the team member to bring a list of 5 things to discuss. At the start of the meeting, they would match lists and talk about whatever is on both lists first. After that, they would spend time on 4 topics · performance on job requirements, relationships with peer teams, leadership and innovation.
1. If you have negative or positive feedback give it right away rather than waiting for the 1-1. However, make sure bi-directional feedback is given at least as often as the 1-1 meeting. The face to face 1-1 is also useful for feedback that the person may be especially sensitive too, or is being given for the second time and needs to be taken more seriously.
1. It's important not to push times of the 1-1's for "more important" tasks. Book them and ensure you always are on time. Similarly, canceling a 1-1 should be a last resort. The exception to this is talent acquisition interviews. If participating in an interview schedule, reschedule the 1:1 with as much advance notice as possible, but prioritize the interview.
1. One communication style does not fit all. Some need very direct feedback. Others work better with FYI style information to then come to the conclusion you want them to come to on their own. Others work well with clear goals, but without a clear prescription as to how to reach the goal. Great managers can adapt their style to the report.
1. It is common to start with a bit of small talk. You can also consider starting with asking how are you as a person?
1. The end of the meeting is a good time to ask questions people might be hesitant to answer. People will often reveal their important information at the end of a conversation. Use this to

get information about things that are bothering them about other people in the company, including you as a manager. Ask a question like 'How can I make your life better?' or 'How's the team and the work with other people?'. Don't put this question on the agenda in advance. Since it is the end of the meeting it might be needed to add it to the agenda to discuss in the next meeting.

1. Setting and managing expectations is maybe your most important task. Both the managers expectations of the work done by the report and the reports expectations about the work and company.

1. Reports tend to assume that they must do everything added by the manager, make it clear that they can push back (not a good idea, not worth the time), and redirect (please handle it directly with this person, can you arrange for this). You want to prevent the agenda piling up. The manager will put items on the agenda because it is in the functional area of the report and the manager doesn't want to bypass them. But in case the manager cares about something and the report doesn't it might be preferable for the manager (or an executive assistant) to do the work.

1. Actively listen to identify what the direct report is saying. The manager should strive to do 20% of the talking while the direct report does 80%.

1. If you have few items on the agenda from the report try the following questions:

- Is there anything that needs clarity?
- What are you most proud of/excited about?
- What can I (your manager) improve on?
- Anything you think important that happened since the last 1-1
- What are potential troubles you see for the team
- What are potential troubles you see for the company
- What went well since last week?
- What went not so well since last week?
- Is there anything I can do to help?
- Anything non-work related worth mentioning?
- When x happened, what will you do differently next time?
- Have you identified any career development opportunities that I can help you with? For

example: Internship for Learning

- Other great questions to consider can be found in the Culture Amp Blog: 24 great one-on-one meeting questions or in 15Five's The Great eBook of Employee Questions.

1. Consider encouraging direct reports to keep their 1:1 document open in their browser throughout the week. As items come up, they can add them in real time instead of waiting until 30 minutes before the meeting to scramble to fill in the agenda.

1. Asking open ended questions is important. "You doing alright?" is a yes/no question. There is no room for an answer unless you dig and prod to get more. Instead asking things like "Tell me how you've been doing since we last talked" leave more room for discussion and result in something both more actionable and results driven. Your goal is not just to know how they are doing, but why they feel that way.

1. Consider populating the agenda to the 1-1 meeting at least 24 hours in advance of the meeting. This will enable the direct report and manager mental space to think more critically about each topic.

Career Development Discussion at the 1-1

These discussions should take place once a month and after the 360 Feedback meeting has taken

place. As a manager of people you play a crucial part in developing careers for your reports. This is for them but you should be able to support this process and help them achieve their goals. This is a joint collaboration so prior to the meeting think about what questions to ask, specifically identifying competencies(c), skill gaps(sg) and career objectives (co). Adrienne Smith who wrote increase employee retention with career pathing suggests the following:

1. Which projects are you most proud of that you've finished here? (c)
1. What is your favorite part of your job? (c)
1. Which projects have you struggled with most in this role? (sg)
1. What's your least favorite part of your day-to-day? (sg)
1. When do you ask for help most often? (sg)
1. What parts of your role do you want to do more of? Less of? (co)
1. What don't you do in your current role that you'd like to? (co)
1. What would you like to learn next? (co)

Once you have established the goals you can then create a career development plan

Why career development for team members is key to being a great leader

Providing team members with a clear path of advancement within the group, department or division that includes career development opportunities is a win-win-win for team members, managers and GitLab. Team members who are challenged, engaged and who are actively contributing relevant solutions stay with organizations. An engaged workforce allows the department and divisions to meet their current and future needs for talent and skills and increases performance and decreases regrettable attrition.

Please make sure as a manager you have reviewed the Career Development Section in the handbook

There are many reasons that career development conversations are important. Below are a few examples though there are many more reasons.

Increase team productivity and performance

For managers, having career development conversations offers them a chance to help develop team members which then has an impact on the overall organization. It's a critical skill for those serious about increasing their teams' productivity and performance. Development conversations will help the group, department, division and GitLab retain great team members, which at the end of the day also contributes to the manager's own success.

Build a bench of high contributors

On top of increasing performance, these career development conversations allow managers to build a bench of top talent contributor and create a succession pipeline. This will help reduce worries about losing top talent and who the team can turn to for critical tasks. Good managers know that if you have a strong bench, you have a lot less to worry about.

Be a great leader

When it comes down to, it the best managers or leaders · the ones that team members want to have and are happy continue being part of the team. These are the managers that take an

interest in their team members lives and career. By learning about what your team members wants, what they strive for and by being able to help them drive to their goals, you will build credibility, trust and respect. This in turns also contributes to your overall success as a manager.

#### Attract, engage and retain top talent

A managers's job is not to just drive to OKRs and performance. It is also to attract, engage and retain top talent team members and maximize their contribution to the group, department or division. If you are interested in your team members aspirations, success and what motivates them, you will attract top talent because people will want to work for you. Once you get great team members on board, you will need a plan to get them and keep them engaged. Career development can be and should be one of the ways you as a manager invest your time and energy to help drive engagement, performance and results.

#### Preparing for a team member's performance and development conversation

##### Career conversations do not have to be intimidating

Career development conversations are vital for the team members, managers and GitLab's success. However, not all managers are prepared to address career development due to either lack of experience in having these conversations or a fear that the conversation will be difficult or unpleasant. Here are a few other reasons that managers may avoid having these conversations:

- Career development conversations will take up time they do not have and create more work
- Team members will want different roles or opportunities on an unrealistic timeframe
- Team members will have aspirations that do not match their current skill level
- Team members will take conversations about their career as a promise of a promotion
- Team members will leave after they have developed new skills

Not discounting these concerns, but as a manager it is your job to engage team members in meaningful career development conversations.

If a team members expectations or timeframe is unrealistic, you can explore having them use their time to find opportunities that will engage and prepare them for when their opportunities arise. If they are ready for promotion but the opportunity is not in scope or plan for the business it is best to be transparent with the team member. Discuss any timeline of if/when a position may be available or if there is no plan currently to add that role. You can also work with the team member to look for internal opportunities like internship or cross collaborative projects to help keep the team member engaged while continuing in their role.

If a team members expresses career ambitions that are beyond their current skill set, then that is an opportunity to talk about the next level skills and experience that might help prepare them to get them where they want to go. If your department or division has job matrices or competencies this is a good time to review those with the team member. Technical skills are only one part of the team members ability to continue to grow and succeed. If there are issues with attitude and behaviors this is a good time to also share what the team member needs to work on in regards soft skills as part of their career growth and development.

If you are concerned that your career development conversation could be construed as a promise

of a promotion, focus the conversation around skills gap development and opportunities. Try to focus on the things needed now rather than focusing on a specific time frame.

It is possible that some team members may leave for other opportunities after they acquire a new skill set. However, it is even more possible that they will leave if they believe you or GitLab is not interested in their career aspirations or development. Engaging in meaningful career development conversations show that you as a manager care about them personally and their future development.

### Preparing for the discussion

#### Strengths and wins

As a manager part of your job is to learn more about the team members you manage. What are their skills, interests and career goals? The tone of the career development conversation should be transparent, encouraging, curious and show that you are interested and invested in the team member. Spend some time before you have a conversation to think about the following:

- The team members key strengths, skills and wins
- The team members engagement level
- What are opportunities for their development
- Current level of skills in technical or functional areas
- What are their strong leadership competencies or behaviors

Career development conversations shouldn't be done on a whim or just "winging it," but instead these should be thought out and conversations that you prepare for ahead of time. You should come prepared to offer team members feedback, offer suggestions and to ask pertinent questions.

#### What questions might team members ask?

Team members want feedback on their strengths, performance and their potential within GitLab. Be prepared to answer the following questions:

- What you say are my top strengths or top skill?
- What skills should I build on?
- Are you aware of any development opportunities that would be helpful for me?
- I see this as my career path, what career path do you see based on my skills?
- Should I be gathering career development feedback from others?

Since you are already having regular 1:1s with your team member you may have ideas regarding your team members development aspirations. Plan ahead and take the time to think about what questions they may ask and come prepared to the conversation.

### Having the discussion

#### Maintain the right frame of mind

Coming to the meeting with an open mind and the willingness to learn more about the team members career development aspirations will set the right tone for the conversation.

A best practice could be having the team member start the meeting by expressing their goals for the conversation. Your job as a manager is to listen and understand their desires and help them explore options that may be available for reaching those goals. Try and refrain from interjecting, let the team member finish before you start talking. Try not to be judgemental on what they say, different people will have different career goals and it is important to respect their ideas. However, this can also be a time for you to provide them with feedback, suggestions, recommendations and guidance. It can also be an opportunity for you to connect them with different people within GitLab and additional resource that support their identified career path.

As a manager you should follow up on the goals and activities you both identify. This will show the team member that you do listen and have a vested interest in their future success. Also, career conversations should not be a one-time annual conversation. A best practice is to meet at least quarterly for a check-in. Keep in mind some team members may want to meet more often and some less frequently.

### Be open about your own career goals and development

If asked, share your career goals with your team members. This transparency shows that you are not only willing to hear their career goals, but you are also willing to share your own career path. That could also include discussing with your team members the areas that you have identified to focus on in the future. Be open about questions regarding your own career path and experiences to date. Your team member may be able to take away some valuable lessons that you have learned in your own journey.

### Additional resources

Below are several recommended articles regarding career development conversations.

- 5 business reasons to put employee career development at the top of your agenda
- Career Development Mentoring Benefits
- Why Employee Development is Important, Neglected and can Cost You Talent
- If You're Not Helping People Develop, You're Not Management Material
- Bolt's Developing Your Team section from their Managing our team playbook.

### Key Points

1. Actively Listen. Self-assessment is difficult and people often overestimate or underestimate their skillset. Don't be quick to discount their assessment. Look for common ground and focus on understanding their overall goals.

1. Control. Maintain control of the conversation to ensure it stays on track. The focus should be on their current skillset and abilities and how to cultivate those for a career path within the company.

1. Adaptation. Adapting your approach to different personality types is key. People that overestimate their skillsets should be given specifics on where they do, and don't, meet expectations. They may need areas of failing to be pointed out more plainly (but always caringly). Those that underestimate their skillset may need more emphasis on what they are doing right as they tend to focus on the negative. Also, not everyone wants to advance. Some are very happy in the role they are in and want to stay there. That should also be supported. Learn more in our Learning & Development Handbook.

## Transitioning 1-1s

When taking over management of an existing team member, consider the following guidelines to ensure the team member experiences a psychologically safe transition.

### Manager Transition Meeting

In an effort to be transparent, managers should consider ensuring that all of the information provided to the future manager by the current manager is done in full view of the team member. This might not work for all team members. You should ask whether the team member will feel comfortable having this conversation openly, and respect their boundaries. When choosing to remain transparent, schedule a transition meeting and follow the Manager Transition Meeting Agenda.

### 1-1-1 Transition Schedule

The following schedule can ensure a smooth transition:

1. Current Manager: Create a 1-1-1 and invite the team member and the future manager
  1. Prior to the meeting get approval from the team member to share the existing 1-1 doc (and other feedback documents) with the future manager. Or, if they request start a new 1-1 document and share it with the team member and the future manager. This will give the future manager an opportunity to review in advance of the meeting.
  1. Team Member: If a new 1-1 document was started, transfer any relevant content
  1. Group: Continue 1-1-1s for up to a month (if needed)
  1. New Manager: Remove the former manager from calendar invites and the 1-1 document

Abrupt 1-1 transitions can threaten a team member's sense of psychological safety and career stability. If this is a concern, consider scheduling follow-on 1-1-1 transition meetings.

### Manager Transition Meeting Agenda (example)

#### Attendees

- Team Member:
- Current Manager:
- Future Manager:

#### Introduction

TEAM MEMBER, in the coming weeks I will transition management support to FUTURE MANAGER. This is an opportunity for you to comment, agree, and disagree with how your performance, feedback, professional goals, growth areas, and 1:1 document content is shared with FUTURE MANAGER. We want to ensure you have a complete picture of the information we share. The goal is to make sure we're transparent in the transition of your career, how you want to grow, and how I can support you.

We understand that this meeting format may feel a bit awkward as we will openly discuss your work performance. This is all in the service of the goal to fully support you.



## Agenda

- Introductions and reason why this manager transition is happening.
- Review most recent performance evaluations, OKRs, and goals.
- Share any additional feedback since recent reviews.
- Are there any follow-on 1-1-1 transition meetings needed?

## Shadowed 1-1

Shadowing a 1-1 is a scenario in which a GitLab team member attends the 1-1 of their manager and their manager's manager. The intent of this model to provide trust through transparency, build connections between team members and leaders who they may not otherwise interact with regularly, and open opportunities for collaboration by providing a broader knowledge to team members. The shadowed 1-1 is exemplified by the CEO having the CEO Shadows attend 1-1s with his direct reports.

## Agenda

Portions of the agenda will be suitable for sharing and others will not. Care should be taken to separate items that could breach our communication guidelines or potentially reveal confidential information. A suggestion on how to handle this would either be to not share the agenda with the shadow(s) or have a separate agenda for private items, these are just suggestions.

## Attendees

Attendance could be limited to direct reports but could also include other people. A suggestion might be to have a sign up for attendance and, in order to maintain the relationship and support expected to arise from 1-1 meetings, alternate shadow weeks with non-shadowed weeks. Suggest having a separate zoom link for shadowed 1-1s.

## Example

An engineering manager decides to open up their 1-1 meetings to their team. The engineering manager checks with their manager that this is acceptable and determines a plan for review. When a shadow will be present, this should be indicated clearly on the agenda. Utilising a separate zoom link, all 3 people join and walk through the agenda. Participation level of the team member is up to the regular participants of the 1-1 but, consider encouraging engagement. At a point where sensitive topics need to be discussed, the team member will be asked to leave.

## Leadership Engagement Check-Ins

Leadership Engagement Check-Ins, (also known as Stay Interviews) are conducted to help leadership improve retention in their teams. It helps them understand why team members stay and what might cause them to leave. In a Leadership Engagement Check-In, people managers ask standard, structured questions in a casual and conversational manner.

## Process

- Cadence: Schedule your Engagement Check-In at least every 6 months with each of your direct

reports. People leaders can repurpose a scheduled 1-1 meeting;

- Format: Use sync communication via Zoom;
- Preparation: Preparation should be done before the meeting by the manager and the team member. The manager should set expectations with their team members prior to the meeting to ensure that the team member feels as comfortable as possible heading into the conversation. Managers can include a copy of this Handbook page so their direct report is fully aware of the specific questions that will be asked during the call. Ask the team member to review the questions and think about them prior to the call. Allow them the opportunity to type responses before the meeting if they wish to do so.
- Questions: Have a look at the below questions and take notes during the meeting.
- Follow up: At the end of the conversation summarize and follow up on any actions.

## Structure

### Opening

Start the conversation by explaining the purpose of the meeting and why it's important to you as a manager. An example is below.

> "Thanks for taking the time to have this check-in conversation. Team member engagement is very important to me, and this talk is a way to better understand how things are going for you and how I can help to improve your experience at GitLab. I would like to talk with you about the reasons you stay with GitLab so I understand what I can do to make this a great place to work for you."

### Questions

It's important to listen and gather feedback from the team member about how they feel about GitLab in an objective manner:

- What do you like most about your job?
- What do you like least about your job?
- How would you describe a great day at work?
- What motivates you to stay at GitLab?
- What would make you consider leaving GitLab?
- If you could change one thing about your job, team or company, what would it be?
- What can I do to support you?

### Scenarios (situations and reactions)

1. Team member has expressed the desire to stay at GitLab and is engaged

- I am so pleased to hear GitLab is a great place for you and really value your input going forward.

- In case there's a change in your feelings I want to make sure you can always speak up, even outside of these engagement check-ins.

1. Team member expressed both reasons to stay but also reasons for leaving

- I really want to thank you for your valuable input and feedback.

- Summarizing what we have discussed I would love to work on an engagement plan so that we can make sure GitLab is a great place to work for you.

- Let's follow up in one week and prepare items we can work on to improve your experience

at GitLab.

1. Team member expressed mostly reasons why they consider leaving and isn't engaged
  - I really want to thank you for your valuable input and feedback.
  - Looking at your concerns I would love to work on an engagement plan so that we can make sure GitLab becomes a great place to work for you.

- Let's follow up in one week and prepare items we can work on to improve your experience at GitLab.

1. Other scenarios

- If you have a scenario different from the above, and/or you need help with messaging, please work with your manager or People Business Partner.

## Closing

To close the Engagement Check-In, summarize the key points discussed, and work with the team member to develop an engagement plan (if applicable). Be sure to end on a positive note. An example is below.

> "Let me summarize what I heard you say about the reasons you stay at GitLab, as well as reasons you might leave. Then, let's develop a plan to make this a great place for you to work. I appreciate you sharing your thoughts with me today. I am committed to doing what I can to make this a great place for you to work."

If, during the Engagement Check-In, issues arise around health, performance, compensation, etc. and you need assistance, please work directly with your manager or your People Business Partner.

## Follow Up

After the call has closed, capture some notes about what was discussed and share with the team member to ensure you heard their feedback correctly. It is important to do this for all team members - even if they had positive feedback about their engagement level.

For team members who had positive feedback, you will want to continue to find opportunities that align to things that make for a positive experience for them. For team members that had constructive feedback, you will want to use your notes as a start of an engagement plan.

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## SECTION: leadership/1-1/suggested-agenda-format.md

This page describes the recommended 1:1 agenda format, and is based on how Sid formats his 1:1 agendas. It also captures how this format is modified for daily standup agendas.

If you are new to 1:1s or not sure how to make your previous experience with 1:1s work in GitLab's culture, this can be a great starting place for you to learn.

Remember that 1:1s are private meetings between a manager and their report, so consistency is secondary to effectiveness - please make sure to find a format that works for you and your team.

## Daily standups agenda

The "hallway" section of the 1:1 agenda is the recommended agenda format for daily standups. At GitLab, daily standups exist to quickly align and accelerate an initiative. They are scheduled for a limited duration. We use a modified meeting agenda with the 1:1 hallway, because it helps to keep track of progress on key open items. There is less risk of important information being lost from week to week, as a net new agenda is not created.

Consider using this Daily standup / Working group example meeting template. For meetings that aren't a daily standup or 1:1 it's recommended to follow the guidance as noted in GitLab Meeting Best Practices.

## Agenda headers

Give your agenda document these headers:

- 1. Performance Management (Optional)
- 1. Career development
- 1. Vision
- 1. Hallway

## Performance management (Optional)

- 1. List reports with high or exceptional performance. Team members with high performance should be recognized and praised.
- 1. List reports who might be underperforming. Err on the side of putting people on too early and taking them off when it turns out there was no underperformance. It is important to bring people up with your manager immediately and not have your manager have to tell you about concerns.

## Career development

An important part of career development is feedback, but that's not all. It also involves training.

Please see our guide on giving career development.

## Vision

- 1. Paint a picture of how things could look in a couple of years.
- 1. Share best practices you've noticed.

## Hallway

- 1. Every item in the hallway section starts with exactly one tag, the tag can come from one of three categories:
  - 1. Timing
    - ISO DATE (example: 2017-05-21 or 2017-05) - indicating when this item will be discussed next
    - RELEASE NUMBER (example: 9.4 or 9.5) - alternative to ISO DATE to indicate when this item will be discussed next
  - 1. Action
    - TODO - report needs to set date of when this will be completed or just do the task,

if we should discuss them report changes them to DISCUSS

- DOTO - manager needs to do something, with this a (case sensitive) search for 'DO' finds all DOTO's and DONE's
- DISCUSS - cover in the next 1:1 meeting
- REVIEW - there is a Merge Request (MR) or document that can be approved, the MR should not be a Work In Progress (WIP)
- HELP - if you need help with anything.
- THINK - if the person who did not put it on the agenda wants time to think about it and discuss it next meeting.
- SING - if added, the person who added it leads a singalong with all willing participants in the meeting.

1. Ready to remove

- FYI - informational, can be removed outside of the meeting by the person who did not put it on the agenda (the audience for the FYI).
- DONE - to be removed by the person who put it on the agenda, only set after any related MR has been merged
- MOVE - if you want to move it outside of the agenda, for example an issue tracker, removal by the person who put it on the agenda
- DUPLICATE - An item that is an outdated duplicate of another item on the agenda, removal by the person who put it on the agenda.
- WONT - if you think this is no longer something that should be done.
- WHY - if you get the suggestion but wonder why this is important and what the problem is.
- IDEA - if the person who put it on the agenda is offering a suggestion for consideration and possible dismissal rather than as a directive.
- THANKS - mostly used by the manager to praise the report, these should not require a follow-up action. There is a tendency to focus on issues and challenges. Do not forget to recognize accomplishments and success.
- SORRY - if you want to say sorry for something.
- FEEDBACK - this is feedback about your performance (also means that all the other items are not performance feedback)

1. It is recommended to provide a section listing frequently used & useful tags that help facilitate ideas and perception triggers when a direct report (or their manager) fills out the 1:1 agenda.

- This helps reassure that all these topic tags are readily available and encouraged to be used. This is especially important for THANKS, SORRY and HELP tags.

1. As specified above, items are removed after being set to DONE. The 1:1 is one list that is continually modified. It is not a meeting agenda that is duplicated every week under a new date.

1. Add items to the end of the agenda. This is easier to do when using a numbered list.

1. The order going through the agenda is last-to-first, this way things that are still top of mind get handled first.

1. Prefix a new item with your name. Do the same for all responses/follow-ups.

1. Use => to indicate a response/followup to an agenda item and prefix with your name. For example: DISCUSS Sid: Should we look into a collaboration with Walmart? => Kate: I think so, I created <https://gitlab.com/gitlab-org/gitlab-ce/issues/101>

1. Use sub-bullets (a, b, c) if there sub topics.

1. Include a link to the agenda in the calendar invite of the 1:1 meeting.

1. Use comments with +mentions in Google Docs only to signal urgency, don't write content down that way since it tends to get lost. Example: +person@example.com urgent because xyz.

1. Link relevant issues, chats, screenshots, and Google Docs liberally.
1. When you link to items, don't use Google Doc links but just paste the full URL in the document. This makes it easier to quickly see what the link points to and makes it easy to copy/paste.
1. When you make a change, link to the diff or merge request instead of the new content itself, this makes it easier to see what the change was.

## Order

We move through the agenda top to bottom by header but bottom to top within those headers. For example, the very first discussion item in the call should be the last item under "Performance management".

## Example Agenda

Consider this example agenda between a manager (Martina) and her direct report (Andre).

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## SECTION: leadership/emotional-intelligence/\_index.md

### Introduction

At GitLab, we place a high level of importance on interpersonal skills for workplace effectiveness. Employee interpersonal skills have an impact on productivity, morale, engagement, performance, and help us live up to our values. Whether you are a People Manager or an Individual Contributor, being skilled in "emotional intelligence" (also referred to as EQ) is a key attribute to interpersonal effectiveness.

One of the most important factors in people's decisions to stay or leave a job is the quality of the relationship they have with their immediate boss and their coworkers. There are practical ways to learn and apply interpersonal skills in a remote environment. In this section of the handbook we review the key characteristics of emotional intelligence (EQ) and how to improve your interpersonal skills professionally and personally. You'll learn how to work more effectively with others.

What is emotional intelligence?

{.shadow.medium.center}

EQ is defined as the ability to understand and manage your own emotions, as well as recognize and influence the emotions of those around you, according to Harvard Business review. At GitLab, we operate in an all-remote environment where team members communicate virtually across the globe. By fostering EQ, we can establish a level of connection in an all-remote environment.

Better EQ provides better relations with remote teams. EQ plays an important role in helping maintain order between teams that consist of diverse cultures and backgrounds. At GitLab, we rely on low-context communications, Slack channels, email, and video calls to get our message

across. There are less opportunities to practice our EQ.

Considering that these communication channels do not always express our true feelings, developing our EQ will be a tool for us to pick up on emotional cues and help us read between the lines to better understand the message.

Learn more about emotional intelligence by watching this session titled Being Human with Claire Doody, hosted by the GitLab L&D team in September, 2022. Hear from more experts in conversations hosted by GitLab with Reini Chipman on Diversity in Emotional Intelligence and Christopher Connors on EQ for Modern Leaders.

{{< youtube "ai6DbsNIOF4" >}}

### Building an inclusive environment with EQ

EQ is a major factor in developing and maintaining cultural awareness. By fostering emotional intelligence, you are able to promote understanding, respect, and good relationships across all teams, regardless of their locations.

It is a tool that is helping GitLab build an inclusive environment for everyone By understanding that others might have different responses and customs based on their upbringing, you can develop social and emotional intelligence.

### Components of EQ

There are five main components of EQ:

| What it's called | What it means | Competencies to measure |  
| ---- | ---- | ---- |  
| Self Awareness. | The ability to identify and understand your own emotions and the impact we have on others. | Emotional Self-Awareness, Accurate Self-Assessment, and Self-Confidence |  
| Social Skills. | The ability to understand the emotions of others through empathy by identifying what others feel and sharing emotion. | Empathy, Organizational Awareness, and Service |  
| Self Regulation. | The ability to manage emotions and behaviors. When we are aware of our emotions we can begin to manage them. | Emotional Self-Control, Transparency, and Adaptability & Initiative |  
| Relationship Management. | The ability to build and maintain healthy relationships through conflict management, teamwork, and to inspire others. | Inspirational Leadership, Influence, Developing Others & Teamwork, and Conflict Management |  
| Motivation. | The ability to pursue goals with energy and persistence and a passion to work for reasons that go beyond money or status. | Optimism , Organizational Commitment, and Achievement |

The components of EQ were developed by psychologist and writer Daniel Goleman and his colleagues. They documented how people with high EQ outperform others in terms of success as managers and executives, yearly sales, and lower turnover rates. Furthermore, they have shown the increasing importance that EQ plays as professionals progress in their careers and reach higher levels of management.

Pure technical skills and intellectual ability are prerequisites for top positions, but they do not differentiate top performers from the rest as well as interpersonal abilities do.

### How to develop your EQ in a remote environment

Click the numbers in the interactive image below to learn more.

```
<div style="width: 100%;"><div style="position: relative; padding-bottom: 99.45%; padding-top: 0; height: 0;"><iframe frameborder="0" width="1083" height="1077" style="position: absolute; top: 0; left: 0; width: 100%; height: 100%;" src="https://view.genially.com/630fb3c75f08a40011b7201c" type="text/html" allowscriptaccess="always" allowfullscreen="true" scrolling="yes" allownetworking="all"></iframe> </div> </div>
```

1. Control your self-expression and perceptions. At GitLab, we rely on written communication and virtual calls as opposed to working in an office where we can rely on in-person interactions. As remote workers, we not only have to collaborate on projects but we are also responsible for building relationships, trust, and rapport with other colleagues through a screen. To build trust with a team, we need to understand how we express emotions to others through various communication methods.

1. Understand how your actions can impact others. At GitLab, our default form of communication is asynchronous through text. Written communication among remote teams can lead to misinterpretations. Be aware of what actions you need to take in delivering a message. Put yourself in the reader's shoes when crafting a message through text. Empathize with them and view the message from multiple audiences.

1. Self-awareness (know yourself). Understanding yourself means being aware of your own emotions, strengths and weaknesses, your values, and what motivates you. There are strategies we will detail below on gaining a better understanding of your own EQ and how it impacts others, but improving your interactions with others begins with self-awareness.

1. Know your stressors (self-regulation). Managing your emotion in stressful situations requires an understanding of how you can adapt to changing situations. Identify what stresses you out and take proactive steps to mitigate them. Keeping your cool and accepting the fact that you can't control everything. An emotionally intelligent person thinks how their emotional expressions affect others.

1. Strengthen your social skills. Team members with strong social skills are able to communicate their thoughts and ideas effectively in a remote setting. At GitLab, we are intentional about using informal communication to strengthen social relationships. Set up a coffee chat or join a team social call to get started. Strengthen your own social skills by actively listening and providing feedback during virtual discussions.

1. Build your motivation. A key component of EQ is having intrinsic motivation to achieve goals. At GitLab, every team member is a manager of one. Being self-motivated (by adopting a self-service and self-learning mentality) should be paramount in defining what you can accomplish in a remote setting. Focus on the aspects of the job you really enjoy and use those to drive your personal and team success forward.

### Emotional Intelligence Manager Competency

Emotional intelligence is a key skillset for all team members at GitLab. For Managers, it is an essential attribute that can help enable team dynamics and ensure your people are receiving the right level of professional development as they progress in their careers.



Skills and behavior of the emotional intelligence manager competency:

- Actively displays self-awareness and self-regulation through the use of empathy
- Models high level of emotional intelligence while balancing with hard and soft skills
- Applies emotional intelligence to personalize their management approach with each team member that focuses on the whole person approach to management
- Drives an organizational strategy and culture that ensures courtesy and politeness in all interactions
- Recognizes pressures/problems faced by team members and provides sympathy and understanding

How to understand your EQ

In order to develop your EQ, you need to understand your current baseline of how developed the skill is. Take one or more of the many free EQ assessments below to gain a better understanding of where you stand. Share the results with your team. If you are a manager, encourage your team to take one of the assessments. Use the results to tailor discussions and interactions with them. The more you know about your team personally and professionally, the more you can strengthen your EQ.

Emotional intelligence (EQ) assessments

1. Color Code Personality Test
1. Global Leadership Foundation EQ Test
1. Mind Tools EQ Quiz
1. University of California at Berkley EQ Assessment
1. Psychology Today EQ Test
1. Growth versus Fixed Mindset Assessment

Related pages on emotional intelligence (EQ)

- Understanding SOCIAL STYLES

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## SECTION: leadership/emotional-intelligence/psychological-safety-short-course.md

Introduction

Welcome to Psychological Safety: Understanding, Empowerment & Self-Reflection

This is a short course designed to help with your understanding of psychological safety, provide pragmatic steps to cultivate a culture of psychological safety within in your team, and reflect on some of your behaviours that may appear psychologically safe or unsafe.

We are doing this to ensure we create an environment where everyone is able to thrive, as well as easily embody our values of Collaboration, Results, Efficiency, DIB, Iteration and Transparency, and the operating principles that accompany this. In this course you will see how certain actions can quickly lead to erosion of these values and the erosion of trust amongst team members.

There are two ways to take the course. You can:

- Watch the videos on Level Up.
- Read the content, which can be done on Level Up where you achieve your badge.

You are free to do both of course, but the content is duplicated across the two mediums.

## Introduction to Psychological Safety

### 1. Review the Psychological Safety Handbook Page

#### 1. Welcome to Psychological Safety: Understanding, Empowerment & Self-Reflection

First, what is psychological safety?

Psychological safety was defined by Amy Edmondson as a "shared belief held by members of a team that the team is safe for interpersonal risk taking". It's not about being warm and fuzzy and sharing your feelings. It's about being comfortable admitting when you are wrong or have made a mistake as well as challenging each other for the better. You can view a great video of Susan David explaining this further in the handbook.

Here is an illustration of what a psychologically safe team and what a psychologically unsafe team would look like:

## Psychological Fear and Psychological Safe

As you can see, the opportunity to live our values in the red zone is very difficult. Collaboration, Iteration, Transparency, and Diversity of thought would disappear. This will ultimately lead to poor results. We want to ensure we create a green environment where everyone is given the freedom to thrive at GitLab.

Creating a Psychological safe environment is much harder in a diverse group of people. The risks to psychological safety is much higher, therefore we have to operate with a much higher intent, and work together, as well as individually, to learn and grow our ability to cultivate these environments.

Cultivating these environments is an ongoing process as team members leave and new ones start. You need to always be operating with psychological safety intentions.

## What Impacts Psychological Safety

In this section we will address 5 key things that effect Psychological Safety, but this is certainly not exhaustive. This section does focus on what negatively impacts Psychological Safety, while in the next section of the course we will address how to tackle some of these issues and how we can cultivate a culture where these things do not arise.

- Punishment culture - If we don't allow reasonable failures to happen, risk taking diminishes, iteration stops, and creativity is stifled. This is a sure fire way to create a culture of "we have always done it this way".
- Not allowing conflict - Disagree and commit is a subvalue at GitLab and is very important in creating an environment where everyone is heard, but still able to move forward. This generates

ideas, ensures many perspectives are taken into consideration when building processes and products, and avoids missing considerations which could have diversity implications.

- Not understanding communication styles - Not recognizing others communication styles means you cannot effectively facilitate conversations and meetings, can miss other points of views, and potentially isolate individuals. This is a great exercise you can do with your team to help understand each others communication style better.
- Blame culture - After we begin a culture of blaming individuals, much like punishment culture you reduce trust in team members developing creative solutions.
- Leaders & Team Members not embracing feedback - If leaders do not take on feedback from team members, trust erodes, messages are not delivered correctly, and misunderstandings happen.

You may be thinking that these are obvious, but in scenarios later in the course you will see how these things can subtly happen and erode psychological safety. Next you will learn what you can do to cultivate psychological safety.

What can you do to promote and cultivate psychological safety as Team members and Leaders?

### Three Practices to Cultivate Psychological Safety

These three great practices will help you really make that push into ensuring that everyone feels psychologically safe.

1. Perception vs Intent - Ensuring that you are being mindful of this on both sides is very important. How could your actions be perceived against what you mean or how you perceived someone's actions, and what their actual intent was? Understanding your team members' communication styles and work styles will go a long way towards avoiding this. We will talk more about awareness of this later in the course.

1. Operate with a high intent - We assume positive intent, including on most occasions when mistakes are made that were not intended. A way to avoid these mistakes is to operate with higher intent.

Higher intent is the practice of recognizing, reevaluating, and reiterating on inclusive practices.

For example, you are an extrovert and enjoy participating in conversations in meetings, but you recognize that you are not the only voice in the meeting and some haven't been heard. You use your confidence to encourage and provide space for other ideas.

This also means acknowledging and apologizing when you get it wrong. People who operate at a higher intent do not use positive intent as a defense but as a learning opportunity.

1. Have moral courage - This is the practice of being brave for ethical and moral reasons, even when it is a risk or inconvenient for you.

Scenario: Someone is consistently using the wrong pronouns for a team member who identifies as non-binary. They use the pronouns They/Them. The person doing this is at the Director level and you have a great relationship with them. After an incident of seeing the director doing this, you ask for a zoom chat and explain the issue.

Risks:

- The person is higher in the hierarchy
- You may not know their conservative or liberal views
- Risking the friendship you have with the person

### Nurturing Psychological Safety for All Team Members

It is important that there are consistent things that we can do to ensure that we nurture and cultivate psychological safety.

Everyone at GitLab can follow these key practices to create and continue the culture we desire:

- Embrace a culture of respectable debate: We have our operating principle of "Disagree, Commit, Disagree" - to help embrace this practice. It allows us to have those conversations that spark creativity, iterations, and gather viewpoints that we may have missed. Our value ensures that we still progress and move forward.
- Encourage and Share personal stories: This is a great way of ensuring that as team members we build relationships and, ultimately, trust at work. Coffee chats are a great avenue for this so that you are more comfortable bringing up pertinent issues.
- Practice self-reflection: We will have a task later in the course to help you practice this, but it is important that you are evaluating how you react and engage in conversations at work under different stress responses.
- Allow for experimentation and failure: Again, this is something that sparks creativity, allows some freedom for projects to not work out, and provides space for our iteration and efficiency values to prosper. We don't want to be stuck in a culture of "we have always done it this way."
- Build a culture of curiosity: Ask questions not only about people's lives (as above), but also about shared personal stories. Be genuinely curious about processes, practices, products, and other things at work. Be curious and respectful.
- Be open to feedback: Always be open to both good and constructive feedback. Receiving constructive feedback should not be psychologically unsafe. Leaders, ensure you understand not only how to give feedback effectively, but also how a team member likes to receive constructive feedback.
- Encourage creative collaboration and collaborative learning: Collaboration is a core value here and we encourage learning. Allow for these things to happen together. For example, someone in your team may have a unique skill. Ask if it is possible for other team members to shadow them when they perform that skill.
- Seek diverse perspectives: To avoid confirmation bias, ask team members from underrepresented groups for their views. It is so important that a diverse set of voices are considered in our day to day work, so actively seek those voices.

### Nurturing Psychological Safety for Leaders

These are specific practices and actions for leaders and future leaders. While nurturing and cultivating psychological safety is everyone's job, leaders are in a unique position and have a disproportionate effect on this.

- Foster a pro diversity mindset and build diverse teams: Try not to build teams where all members look and act the same. Leverage your power to hire and promote from underrepresented groups (URGs), regions, and skills while still ensuring this is based on merit.
- Highlight competencies of team members: Much like collaborative learning, ensure you are

letting team members know who within the team are subject matter experts. People can learn from them, but it also help elevate their voices on certain issues. Get to know your team members.

- Try to remove biases such as contrast and compare: Each team member is unique and was hired based on their strengths, try to avoid contrasting and comparing when evaluating performance, etc.
- Participative management: Try to dismantle perceptions of hierarchy by ensuring you are part of the team and not just the leader of the team.
- Avoid blame & keep negative feedback 1-1

### Self Reflection Exercise

- What are your stress responses (when you are excited, angry, stressed, etc)? For example:
  - "When I am excited I am animated with my hands."
  - "When I am stressed with work I am less transparent and tend to shut off."
  - "When I am stressed in my personal life I can get distracted."
  - "When I am excited I tend to interrupt people."
  - "When something stressful happens I tend to panic."
  - "When something stressful happens I tend to be defensive."
- What are your actions when you are passionate and excited?
- How do you react to frustrated team members?
- Can your actions and responses be considered psychologically safe? For example:
  - "I am animated with my hands which can cause sensory overload for someone who is neurodivergent." Still, on most occasions it is safe.
  - "I interrupt people often when I am excited which can cause frustration and make people feel as though their voice is not heard." This can be unsafe.
- Have you provided your intent? For example:
  - "I want everyone to be aware that when stressful things happen I can shut off and just put my head down. If you notice this and feel I am not being transparent about activities please let me know."
  - "I am aware that when I am excited I tend to cut people off. Please call me out on this behavior when it happens as I often don't realize I am doing it."
- What are your unconscious biases and have you challenged them?
- Do you consciously evaluate your unconscious biases when communicating?
- How do you like to receive feedback? Do you give feedback the same way? Does your team know how you like to receive feedback, and do you know how they prefer feedback?
- What constitutes psychologically unsafe behavior? Leaders and team members can provide feedback that, for example, isn't itself psychologically unsafe, but someone may feel that any feedback makes them feel unsafe. Challenge your assumptions on whether it is truly unsafe or part of the work.

### Psychological Safety Manager 1:1

This is a guide on how to conduct a 1:1 with your direct reports after they have completed the Psychological Safety Short Course.

1. If your direct reports are taking the course ensure you have completed the course too here
1. Create a safe space to share.
  - No need to keep notes
  - Be conversational
  - Share scenarios or anecdotes

1. Be vulnerable, share your learnings from the course and your commitments to psychological safety after taking the course.
1. Challenge team members to share authentically and ask follow up questions to help team members share.

### Example Agenda

- What are one or two things that you learnt from the course, was there anything that surprised you?
- What were some of the learnings that came out of the self reflection exercise and how do you plan to use those learnings moving forward?
- How can I support you as a manager or anything I can do to make our relationship more psychologically safe and for the team at large?
- What is one personal commitment that you will make moving forward to psychological safety?

### Scenarios & Quiz

You can view scenarios here and take the quiz via Level Up.

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## SECTION: leadership/emotional-intelligence/psychological-safety.md

### Introduction

On this page we are going to review psychological safety and its importance for successful teams.

### What is Psychological Safety

Psychological safety is defined by Amy Edmondson as a "shared belief held by members of a team that the team is safe for interpersonal risk taking".

It's not about being warm and fuzzy and sharing your feelings. It's about being comfortable admitting when you are wrong or have made a mistake as well as challenging each other for the better.

Watch the video below where Susan David explains psychological safety.

{{< youtube "O0kAMpRp2hU" >}}

### How it Works

The following information was summarized from an article on Psychological Safety by PeopleTalking.

Psychological Safety has primary importance when it comes to significant impact on a team's performance.

The other factors that have an impact on a team's performance are: Dependability, Structure,

Meaning & Clarity, Impact.

In addition, the factors of Accountability, Open Communication & Motivation, Dialogue Practices, and Shared Assumptions are only valuable when the team is already psychologically safe. In the diagram, those lie on the arrows between each of the circles.

Why is psychological safety important? When you have psychological safety in the workplace, the following things increase:

- Collaboration
- Innovation
- Inclusion
- Well-being
- Culture

Amy Edmondson uses David Kantor's model to show the relationship between Psychological Safety and Accountability & Motivation. When there is an environment where psychological safety is low or non-existent, it can be very stress or anxiety filled. When there is high psychological safety, it can make people more comfortable. You can get a better picture of this from the diagram below.

### Psychological Safety vs Danger

When you have psychological safety people become more motivated because they feel more able to take risks. When people feel psychologically safe, they will learn from their failure rather than feeling the need to blame others.

### Diversity and Inclusion

Psychological safety has impacts on diversity and inclusion in organizations. Even if an organization has diversity, it doesn't mean that inclusion is present as well.

### Strategies for Cultivating a Culture of Psychological Safety

1. Embrace a culture of respectful debate.
1. Encourage personal storytelling.
1. Ask questions.
1. Allow for experimentation and failure.
1. Dismantle perceptions of hierarchy.
1. Model openness to feedback.
1. Set clear goals and key performance indicators.
1. Offer development opportunities.
1. Build a speak-up culture.
1. Highlight competencies.

The above list is from a Grant Thornton article.

It is important to enable a human-to-human approach and realize the other party is more like you than different. The reflection activity called "Just Like Me", developed by Paul Santagata, asks you to consider:

- This person has beliefs, perspectives, and opinions, just like me.
- This person has hopes, anxieties, and vulnerabilities, just like me.
- This person has friends, family, and perhaps children who love them, just like me.
- This person wants to feel respected, appreciated, and competent, just like me.
- This person wishes for peace, joy, and happiness, just like me.

## Psychological Safety Learning & Development

{{% alert %}}

### Psychological Safety Short Course

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{{% /alert %}}

If you want to learn more about how you can impact psychological safety, you can take the Psychological Safety Short Course which takes approximately 30-45mins. This will guide you through things that impact psychological safety, how you can cultivate psychological safety as well as run through scenarios to reaffirm your learning.

You can:

- Access the Psychological Safety Short Course [here](#).
- Read the content of the course [here](#).

## Live Learning Session

During Week 3 of our Manager Challenge Pilot, we had a course covering Building an Inclusive & Belonging Environment. The slide deck and meeting agenda follow along with the session.

A recording of the second of two sessions can be found [here](#):

{{< youtube "pdB-WWeXNjg" >}}

## One Week Challenge

We rolled out a One week challenge in November 2020. All details relating to the challenge can be found [here](#) on this page.

The One Week Challenge is a blended learning approach that incorporates self-paced daily challenges and live learning sessions to build knowledge and skills around Psychological Safety.

The challenge was organized in an Epic. Each day of the challenge was an issue within the epic with specific tasks for each day. Participation was tracked based on engagement in the issues, attending and participating in one of the live learning sessions, and completing the self



reflection and evaluation forms.

#### Program Overview

- 3 Daily Challenges (20 minutes)
- 1 Live Learning Sessions (1 hour)
- 1 Weekly Self Reflection and Evaluation (10 minutes)
- Certification Upon Completion

#### Learning Objectives

1. Define Psychological Safety
1. Identify the importa